Large Language Models for Bayesian Network Parameterization in Software Engineering: Direct Elicitation versus Ranked Nodes

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Abstract

Bayesian networks can support inspectable software engineering decisions, but constructing their conditional probability tables (CPTs) is costly. Large language models (LLMs) offer a source of probability judgments; compact elicitation methods may reduce the number required while constraining the resulting tables. We compare direct CPT elicitation with an LLM-assisted Ranked Nodes Method (RNM) across 61 ordinal conditional nodes in seven software engineering networks. Eight conditions cross elicitation method, structured prompting, and qualitative retrieval-augmented generation, with five replications requested from GPT-6 Astra at medium effort. Reference CPTs are hidden from elicitation and experimental fitting. On 25 multi-parent targets with non-anchor configurations, RNM lowers mean total variation from 0.3184 to 0.2761 for an RNM-derived Scrum reference but raises it from 0.2223 to 0.2517 for Chrome. Both contrasts survive Holm-adjusted paired t-tests; neither rejects an exact sign test with five blocks. Structured prompting and qualitative evidence provide no consistent improvement. RNM requests 40.1% fewer distributions and uses 12.1% fewer output tokens across all targets, but only 0.61% fewer total tokens. These exploratory results show a representation-dependent accuracy–effort tradeoff: fewer elicited judgments can help on a compatible reference while worsening agreement on another.

CCS Concepts

• **Computing methodologies** → **Bayesian networks**; • **Software and its engineering** → *Software creation and management*.

Keywords

Bayesian networks, large language models, probability elicitation, ranked nodes, software engineering

1 Introduction

Software engineering decisions involve uncertain evidence about release readiness, defect risk, and process weaknesses. Practitioners using machine learning may need to inspect a recommendation's assumptions and understand how it changes with new evidence. Cao et al.'s review identifies 108 explainability studies across 23 software engineering (SE) tasks, including defect prediction and vulnerability detection [2].

Bayesian networks (BNs) explicitly represent variables, dependencies, and conditional probabilities, combining observations with expert knowledge when organizational data are limited. Rique et al.'s mapping of 106 studies identifies software management and quality as prominent applications, alongside knowledge-acquisition and validation challenges [15]. Constructing conditional probability tables (CPTs) is particularly costly as parent-state combinations multiply [1, 8].

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Large language models (LLMs) offer another source of judgments. Within the neurosymbolic agenda of combining neural learning with explicit representations [5], BIRD integrates LLM-derived factors with Bayesian inference [7], while Nafar et al. directly elicit BN parameters [14]. Such parameters can be inspected and revised, but their numerical fidelity requires evaluation.

Should an LLM specify every CPT row or supply selected judgments for reconstruction? The Ranked Nodes Method (RNM) represents ordinal relationships through weighted aggregation and a truncated-normal construction [8]. Our pipeline elicits distributions for selected parent configurations, called anchors, and an aggregation family, then fits the remaining parameters. Fewer judgments come with representational constraints [12]. We test this tradeoff alongside structured prompting and retrieval-augmented generation (RAG).

We compare direct elicitation and RNM across 61 ordinal conditional nodes in seven SE networks. Eight conditions cross method, prompt, and qualitative evidence, with five replications requested from GPT-6 Astra at medium effort (2,440 initial trials). References are hidden from elicitation and experimental fitting. The primary comparison scores both methods on identical non-anchor configurations of 25 multi-parent targets. We ask:

- **RQ1—Reference agreement:** Does RNM reduce total variation distance relative to direct elicitation on the same non-anchor configurations?
- **RQ2—Elicitation support:** How do structured prompting and qualitative RAG affect each method's agreement across complete tables?
- **RQ3—Accuracy and effort:** What tradeoff does RNM achieve between reference agreement, requested judgments, and observed computational effort?

RNM lowers primary total variation from 0.3184 to 0.2761 for the RNM-derived Scrum reference but raises it from 0.2223 to 0.2517 for Chrome. Both directions recur in all five replications and survive Holm-adjusted t-tests, but not exact sign tests. Prompting and qualitative RAG offer no consistent improvement. RNM requests 40.1% fewer vectors and uses 12.1% fewer output tokens, but only 0.61% fewer total tokens.

We contribute a controlled elicitation comparison and diagnostics connecting judgments, fitted tables, and effort. The SE restriction and statistical analyses are post hoc, limiting inference to repeated executions on these references. Explainability motivates the application; effects on practitioners and downstream decisions remain open.

2 Related Work

Our comparison connects inspectable SE decision models, LLM probability elicitation, and methods for reducing elicitation burden. Numerical CPT fidelity is distinct from model usability or downstream reasoning performance.

2.1 Inspectable decision models and hybrid AI

Choosing an explanation approach depends on task fitness, model compatibility, and stakeholder preferences [2]. Expert-based BN construction combines knowledge gathering and reasoning, with uneven validation practices [15]. These findings motivate engineering inspectable models while separately validating their assumptions and parameters.

BIRD combines LLM-generated factors and coarse probabilities through constrained fitting and Bayesian inference [7], illustrating a neurosymbolic approach [5]. Its intrinsic evaluation concerns human judgments of relative support; downstream evaluations concern reasoning. We instead assess numerical parameterization with fixed graphs and definitions, without inferring explanation quality or causal validity.

2.2 LLM elicitation of probabilistic knowledge

Nafar et al. elicit probabilities for 80 public BNs using whole-row distributions or separate statewise queries, evaluating BN and CPT Kullback–Leibler divergence [14]. Statewise elicitation performs better for seven of eight tested models, with more queries. Their Expert-Driven Priors subsequently combine estimates with observations. Prompt variants suppressing reasoning or adding network context leave aggregate results unchanged.

Their comparison changes granularity within a row; ours tests compression across parent configurations, scoring direct and reconstructed predictions on identical non-anchor rows. Different metrics, aggregation, models, and benchmarks preclude ranking the studies by reported errors.

AutoElicit constructs priors from LLM knowledge and natural-language guidance, improving prediction over uninformative priors in its evaluated settings [3]. Such benefits after Bayesian updating do not measure recovery of reference CPTs.

2.3 Partial elicitation and constrained reconstruction

Fenton et al. construct ranked-node CPTs using doubly truncated normal distributions centered on weighted parent functions [8]. Laitila and Virtanen connect RNM to continuous regression and examine its fit to real-world CPTs [12]. Useful approximation depends on modeling choices: ordinal ordering alone does not establish compatibility with an aggregation family, influence alignment, or dispersion specification.

Barons et al.'s InterBeta reconstructs portions of CPTs elicited from experts, evaluating the burden–fidelity tradeoff beyond the elicited subset [1]. We fit experimental RNM predictions only to LLM anchors. Fits using reference probabilities are separate approximation diagnostics, with information unavailable during elicitation. They do not establish an irreducible error floor.

2.4 Evidence support and the accuracy–effort tradeoff

Cypko et al. retrieve clinical guidance for BN modeling, evaluating retrieval and usability with four clinicians, rather than complete numerical CPT agreement [4]. Gottal and Matthes compare reconstruction strategies and direct LLM output using statistical summaries [9]. Those summaries, like observations incorporated by Nafar et al. [14], supply numerical evidence.

Our fixed qualitative packets exclude reference probabilities and numerical parameters. Since both arms already receive node definitions, we test their incremental contribution. Structured prompting is likewise a bundled treatment, not a test of isolated psychological mechanisms.

Human elicitation targets expert burden [1]; LLM query designs change computational demands [14]. We distinguish requested vectors, calls, output and total tokens, repairs, and fitting time, testing whether reduced elicitation also improves fidelity on SE references.

3 Method

We conducted a repeated, factorial comparison of direct CPT elicitation and LLM-assisted RNM reconstruction. The graph, variable meanings, state mappings, elicitation templates, and numerical implementation were fixed before formal collection. Our hypotheses predicted lower non-anchor error with RNM (RQ1), improved agreement from structured prompting and qualitative evidence (RQ2), and fewer requested distributions and output tokens with RNM (RQ3). The subsequent restriction to SE and the statistical test plan were developed after inspecting the broader results. We therefore report an exploratory analysis of a fixed benchmark, rather than a preregistered confirmatory experiment.

3.1 Sample and reference construction

The source pool was an availability-based collection of accessible published models and an existing Scrum model, screened for usable CPTs and definitions; it was not a systematic or representative sample of SE applications. Table 1 describes the 61 retained conditional targets in seven networks from five model/source families. Eligibility required a complete numerical reference, interpretable definitions, and an ordinal interpretation for the child and every parent. Binary variables qualified only when their meanings supported an order; nominal families and Boolean gate chains were outside scope. The references cover Scrum practices, Chrome code review and defects [11], ERP data quality for advanced planning and scheduling (APS) [10], software maintenance logs [6], and software strategic indicators (SESSI) [13]. The two Chrome versions share one publication family, as do the two software-log networks.

The Scrum reference is the full model: 25 conditional targets and 17 fixed roots, extending beyond the teamwork fragment used during development. The accompanying thesis descriptions and company questionnaire supplied construct meanings; English endpoint paraphrases operationalized them for this experiment, without claiming a newly validated generic instrument. The XML supplies the numerical reference and stores functions, weights, variances, and expressions rather than complete CPTs. We reconstructed its 249 conditional rows using equal-width ordinal intervals and five endpoint-inclusive integration points per parent state. The reconstruction explicitly preserves two piecewise expressions and the reversed storage order of a volatility variable. Numerical checks and agreement with the earlier fragment support implementation consistency, but do not certify equivalence to a full AgenaRisk CPT export. This RNM-derived reference is reported separately because

Table 1: Retained targets and requested rows per prompt/evidence combination and replication. Primary targets have at least two parents and at least one non-anchor row.

Network	Targets	Primary	CPT rows	Anchors
Scrum	25	14	249	123
Chrome 40	15	6	78	57
Chrome 42	12	5	63	46
APS	3	0	8	8
SESSI	1	0	3	3
Software logs 3	4	0	16	12
Software logs 4	1	0	4	3
Total	61	25	421	252

its construction favors compatibility with an RNM representation, and the development work already involved the Scrum model.

External references use complete exported tables with checked dimensions, finite nonnegative entries, normalization, and parent/child indexing. Source papers informed definitions and semantic ordering; the frozen exports determine the numerical reference. The SESSI target uses the complete originally elicited table in Appendix A3, rather than claiming recovery of the later recalibrated model. Six other Mendes networks were excluded because complete CPTs were unavailable. The original collection contained 77 targets; the disclosed SE restriction removes 14 marine-risk and two digital-twin targets and drops the domain-comparison RQ. Existing responses were retained without recollection. Earlier pilot and smoke-test answers are excluded. The largest retained CPT has 27 rows.

The primary subset contains 14 Scrum and 11 Chrome targets. The remaining 36 targets support complete-table and effort analyses, but do not satisfy the multi-parent compression criterion. References are contextual model parameters, not established probabilities for arbitrary companies.

3.2 Elicitation conditions and qualitative evidence

The $2 \times 2 \times 2$ design crosses method (direct/RNM), prompt (baseline/structured), and evidence (no RAG/qualitative RAG). All conditions receive the same relevant expert-role description, setting, child and parent definitions, state labels, storage order, semantic ranks, and parent influence signs. The requested distribution conditions on *all* listed parent states and averages over unspecified circumstances. It neither fixes omitted circumstances to a middle state nor assumes independence. A persona supplies a professional perspective, without asserting access to company observations.

The baseline asks for normalized distributions in a fixed JSON schema. The structured bundle additionally makes conditioning explicit, frames probabilities as expected counts among 100 hypothetical comparable cases (fractional counts allowed), distinguishes evidence from assumptions, and requests consistency and normalization checks. These cases are a judgment aid, not observations. A brief evidence note is requested; the experiment does not collect private reasoning traces. Because the instructions form one treatment, their individual effects cannot be separated.

Direct elicitation requests every CPT row in one initial call. RNM requests only predetermined anchors and an aggregation family: weighted mean, weighted minimum, weighted maximum, or a minimum–maximum mixture. Unary targets use the identity family. The LLM supplies no weights or variance; these are fitted offline to its anchor distributions. Both methods receive the same influence signs, although only RNM imposes the corresponding monotonic aggregation constraint. Of the 92 retained parent relationships, nine signs were construct-supported, 43 based on qualitative context, and 40 explicitly marked as uncertain pre-collection hypotheses. Thus, the comparison includes the consequences of these frozen direction assumptions.

RAG consists of fixed, audited qualitative evidence cards. An offline retriever filters by source context, scores exact overlap between variable tags and the child-plus-parent set (wildcards contribute 0.25), and selects up to three positive-scoring cards, breaking ties by card identifier. The budget is 220 words; the prepared maximum is 103. Packets exclude reference probabilities, priors, weights, variances, numerical source results, and identifying links to reference artifacts. Measurement definitions remain permissible. Both evidence arms already contain substantive variable definitions. This treatment therefore tests the incremental value of selected qualitative information, rather than live retrieval performance or access to company-specific frequencies. Packet lengths vary across nodes; input-token budgets are not equalized.

3.3 Ranked-node reconstruction

Following the ranked-node construction [8, 12], each variable with c states partitions $[0, 1]$ into c equal intervals. Negative parent influences reverse semantic rank before aggregation; fitted probabilities are mapped back to the stored child order. Anchors include all-low, all-high, all-middle (rank $\lfloor (c-1)/2 \rfloor$ for each parent), each one-high/rest-low configuration, and each one-low/rest-high configuration, with duplicates removed. Selection uses no reference probabilities. For example, two ternary parents give nine rows, of which five are anchors: $(0, 0)$, $(2, 2)$, $(1, 1)$, $(2, 0)$, and $(0, 2)$. RNM reconstructs the other four; direct predictions are evaluated on those same four for RQ1.

For k parents, let G_r be the Cartesian product of five equally spaced, endpoint-inclusive points within each parent interval for row r. With standard-normal CDF Φ, child interval $[a_s, b_s]$, aggregation mean μ, and variance v, define

$$T_s(\mu, v) = \frac{\Phi((b_s - \mu)/\sqrt{v}) - \Phi((a_s - \mu)/\sqrt{v})}{\Phi((1 - \mu)/\sqrt{v}) - \Phi(-\mu/\sqrt{v})}. \tag{1}$$

The predicted probability is $q_{rs} = 5^{-k} \sum_{x \in G_r} T_s(f(x; w), v)$. Each truncated distribution is normalized before averaging. The mean

functions are

$$f_{\text{mean}}(x; w) = \frac{\sum_i w_i x_i}{\sum_i w_i}, \tag{2}$$

$$g_i(x; w) = \frac{w_i x_i + \sum_{j \neq i} x_j}{w_i + k - 1}, \tag{3}$$

$$f_{\min} = \min_i g_i, \qquad f_{\max} = \max_i g_i, \tag{4}$$

$$f_{\text{mix}}(x; a) = (1 - a) \min_i x_i + a \max_i x_i. \tag{5}$$

The unary mean is x_1. Weighted-mean log weight ratios relative to the last parent lie in $[-6, 6]$; weighted-minimum/maximum weights lie in $[1, 20]$; $a \in [0, 1]$; and $v \in [10^{-4}, 1]$. Variance and minimum/maximum weights use logarithmic parameterizations.

For the family selected by the LLM, the fitter minimizes mean anchor total variation between fitted and elicited distributions. It uses eight deterministic starts (seed 42), coordinate-search steps 2^{-2} through 2^{-11} on normalized parameter coordinates, at most 20 sweeps per step, and an improvement threshold of 10^{-12}. Ties retain the earlier candidate. This seed controls fitting, not LLM sampling. The fitter accepts no reference CPT input. A poor valid fit remains an outcome; similar tables can arise from different parameters, so agreement does not establish parameter recovery. Reference-informed fits were computed separately after predictions were fixed, solely to diagnose approximation limits.

3.4 Execution, isolation, and validation

Five replications were collected on 15–16 October 2026 through signed-in Codex CLI 0.162.1 on a separate Windows computer, requesting `gpt-6-astra` with `medium` reasoning effort. The logs establish the requested configuration; actual serving-model identity was not independently verified. Each target–condition–replication used a fresh ephemeral session. No sampling temperature or generation seed was specified, and generation timeout and output limits remained client-managed. The original 616-template blocks were shuffled using Python's `Random(20261014+r)`, for replications $r = 1, \ldots, 5$. The retained 488 templates inherit those actual positions; they were not separately randomized after the scope restriction.

Reference files, full papers, evaluator code, and authoring conversations were excluded from the experimental computer/sessions. Browser, connector, memory, and tool controls were disabled and event logs inspected. Both arms received only their designated semantic inputs and evidence. This separation reduces direct access leakage, but cannot rule out memorization of public CPTs during pretraining or unobservable service context.

Validation checked identifiers, row completeness, state cardinalities, allowed evidence identifiers and function families, finite probabilities in $[0, 1]$, and row sums within 10^{-6} of one. Only residual normalization within tolerance was permitted and recorded. At most one fresh-session format repair supplied the original task, its own answer, and validation errors, without reference feedback. The failure policy retained valid direct rows with uniform replacements for unresolved rows; unresolved RNM contracts or fitting failures received a uniform node fallback. Runtime/control anomalies paused collection for inspection. No fallback was required in the retained results.

3.5 Outcomes and statistical analysis

For reference row p and prediction q, the primary distance is

$$\text{TV}(p, q) = \tfrac{1}{2} \sum_s |p_s - q_s| \in [0, 1], \tag{6}$$

where lower values indicate closer reference agreement. RQ1 uses identical non-anchor configurations for both methods. Within each replication, we average rows within targets, targets within networks, and networks within publication families, then average the four prompt/evidence cells equally. Scrum is an equal-target mean reported separately; Chrome gives its two versions equal weight. We do not pool their primary effects.

RQ2 uses all rows and contrasts structured minus baseline or RAG minus no RAG within each method, averaging the other factor equally. Scrum remains separate; the external SE macro-average gives equal weight to four publication families. It is broader than the Chrome-only primary comparison. Secondary calculations retain Jensen–Shannon divergence in bits, mean absolute ordinal-CDF differences, and smoothed row-weighted CPT KL divergence. KL adds 10^{-8} to each state and renormalizes; its row weighting differs from the primary macro-average and it is not whole-network KL. The results below emphasize the frozen TV endpoint.

For RQ3, we count requested vectors and scalars before repairs, and aggregate client-reported input and output tokens across *all attempts*, including repairs. Total tokens are input plus output; cached-input and reasoning-output counters are subsets and are not added again. Paired effort contrasts use each method's replication totals, both for all 61 targets and the 25 primary targets. Summed request latency, repairs, and recorded offline fitting durations provide additional effort descriptions. Token counts from subscription execution are not converted into API-priced monetary savings.

The inferential unit is the replication block ($n = 5$), not a node, row, or treatment cell. We use two-sided paired Student t-tests with four degrees of freedom and pointwise 95% t intervals on block differences. These concern repeated executions on the fixed benchmark, assuming approximately normal, independent, stationary differences. Fresh sessions and shuffled order do not establish those assumptions, and five blocks provide little distributional evidence. A two-sided exact sign test checks sensitivity to block directions under independence; it addresses a direction/median null rather than exactly the same mean null. Even five concordant nonzero differences yield $p = 0.0625$.

Holm adjustments are applied separately to two primary contrasts, eight prompt/RAG contrasts, four token contrasts, and two same-anchor fitting contrasts. This is exploratory family-wise adjustment, not study-wide confirmatory control; intervals are not simultaneous. Other family and sensitivity comparisons are descriptive. No smallest effect of interest or equivalence margin was fixed, so significance does not establish practical usefulness and nonsignificance does not establish equivalence. No inference to arbitrary companies or unseen networks is warranted.

4 Results

All five replications are complete: 488 retained initial trials per replication and 305 per treatment cell, totaling 2,440. Four format repairs (two per method) produce 2,444 attempts, with no uniform

fallbacks. The audit rechecked 14,664 raw-file hashes and found no unexpected tool events or unresolved runtime errors. A service reconnect followed by a valid completed answer was retained without rerunning that request. Schema and control validation do not constitute an exhaustive human audit of evidence fidelity. All reported predictions and scores reuse the completed collection.

4.1 RQ1: Contrasting reference agreement

Table 2 reports the primary non-anchor comparisons separately. Table 3 shows all eight conditions, with the broader complete-table endpoints alongside them. Negative RNM-minus-direct differences favor RNM.

Scrum. RNM reduces primary TV from 0.3184 to 0.2761, an absolute change of −0.0423 (13.3% relative reduction). The paired statistic is $t(4) = -18.68$; its interval excludes zero and its Holm-adjusted p is 4.83×10^{-5}. The five replication differences are −0.0454, −0.0341, −0.0473, −0.0415, and −0.0431. RNM is descriptively better on 12 of 14 targets and in each matched prompt/evidence cell. This supports the hypothesized direction for the reconstructed Scrum reference under the paired-t assumptions.

Chrome. RNM raises primary TV from 0.2223 to 0.2517, an absolute change of +0.0294 (13.2% relative increase), opposing the hypothesis. The paired statistic is $t(4) = 23.37$ and the Holm-adjusted p is 3.97×10^{-5}. Replication differences are +0.0341, +0.0277, +0.0268, +0.0294, and +0.0291. RNM is descriptively better on only three of 11 targets and worse in every matched prompt/evidence cell. Both primary directions are consistent across replications, but neither exact sign test reaches 0.05. The evidence therefore combines stable observed directions with dependence of statistical rejection on the small-sample parametric assumptions; it does not establish practical importance.

Elicited anchors versus fitted probabilities. Table 4 separates raw LLM judgments from RNM reconstruction on identical anchor configurations. On Scrum, fitting changes anchor TV only slightly, from 0.2790 to 0.2762 ($\Delta = -0.0028$, 95% CI $[-0.0053, -0.0003]$, raw and Holm t $p = 0.0352$). On Chrome it increases anchor TV from 0.2491 to 0.2994 ($\Delta = +0.0503$, CI $[0.0430, 0.0576]$, raw $p = 4.46 \times 10^{-5}$, Holm $p = 8.93\times10^{-5}$). Both adjusted sign-test values are 0.125. The Chrome deterioration therefore occurs even where the model was explicitly queried. Non-anchor and anchor errors concern different rows and cannot be subtracted as an additive error decomposition.

Reference-informed diagnostics help assess representation compatibility without replacing the experimental outputs. Holding the LLM-selected families fixed, bounded fitting to complete reference tables finds mean all-row TV of 0.1254 for Scrum and 0.2338 for Chrome. Even fitting exact Chrome reference anchors leaves non-anchor TV of 0.2702. These are best-found approximations under the specified search, not proven minimum errors. Four Chrome primary targets have mean-direction reversals under the frozen influence alignment and six have stochastic-order reversals. Scrum also has two targets with reversals: a volatility-direction mismatch and a piecewise backlog relationship simplified by a global family. Omitting the volatility target descriptively leaves the Scrum difference at −0.0402; the seven Chrome targets without mean-direction reversal still give +0.0502. These observations are consistent with an effect of representation and direction assumptions, but do not isolate a causal explanation or justify post-hoc exclusions.

For complete tables, Scrum TV changes from 0.2605 to 0.2334. The external family-specific changes are Chrome 0.2029 to 0.2278, APS 0.0964 to 0.1155, SESSI 0.1160 to 0.1143, and software logs 0.2927 to 0.4034. The equal-family external mean is 0.1770 versus 0.2153. Excluding the single SESSI target, which otherwise has one family weight, gives 0.1973 versus 0.2489 and preserves the direction. These descriptive endpoints cover all 61 targets, including unary and fully anchor-covered cases; they do not expand the primary compression sample.

4.2 RQ2: Structured prompts and qualitative RAG

Table 5 reports within-method effects on complete-table TV. For direct Scrum elicitation, structured prompting reduces TV by 0.0069, whereas qualitative RAG increases it by 0.0043; both survive the eight-test Holm correction under the paired-t model. The RNM Scrum contrasts do not survive correction. None of the four external SE macro-average contrasts survives correction, and no exact sign test in this eight-contrast family rejects at 0.05. The prompt and RAG hypotheses therefore receive no consistent support across methods and reference strata. These results concern the tested instruction bundle and qualitative packets; they do not establish equivalence or rule out benefits from informative numerical evidence.

4.3 RQ3: Accuracy and observed effort

Across all 61 targets, RNM requests 5,040 probability vectors instead of 8,420, a 40.1% reduction; requested scalars decrease from 24,740 to 14,700. This reduction is a property of the anchor design. Initial calls remain equal at 1,220 per method, as do attempts including repairs (1,222 each). Observed output-token reductions support the effort hypothesis, but their magnitude is smaller than the reduction in requested judgments (Table 6).

All-sample output use falls by 12.1%, while input-plus-output use falls by only 0.61%; the latter interval includes zero. For the 25 primary targets, output and total reductions are 28.3% and 2.94%, respectively, and both paired-t contrasts survive correction. None of the four exact sign tests rejects after correction. Inputs dominate the overall totals: 14,355,937 for direct and 14,307,719 for RNM. The reported reasoning-output subsets are 9,890 and 47,053, respectively. Shared input costs and additional RNM family-selection work are consistent with the limited translation from fewer vectors to total-token savings, although these components were not independently manipulated.

Summed client request latency is 14,696.6 seconds for direct and 14,135.2 for RNM, a descriptive 3.82% reduction. These sums are affected by service behavior, caching, and execution order; they are not elapsed times of separate method-only experiments. Offline reconstruction adds 182.3 seconds summed over 1,059 distinct retained fit keys in the original parallel fitting run. This is recorded per-fit elapsed time, not CPU time or a measured SE-only wall-clock duration. Evidence preparation labor was not timed. The observed tradeoff is consequently output compression with better agreement on Scrum and worse agreement on Chrome; neither universal accuracy gains nor large total-token savings follow.

Table 2: Primary non-anchor TV, averaged across prompt/evidence conditions and five replications. Δ is RNM minus direct. Intervals are pointwise; Holm adjustment covers the two strata. Exact sign tests give raw $p = 0.0625$ and adjusted $p = 0.125$ for each.

Reference	Targets	Direct	RNM	Δ	95% CI for Δ	Raw t p	Holm t p
Scrum	14	0.3184	0.2761	−0.0423	[−0.0486, −0.0360]	4.83×10^{-5}	4.83×10^{-5}
Chrome	11	0.2223	0.2517	+0.0294	[+0.0259, +0.0329]	1.99×10^{-5}	3.97×10^{-5}

Table 3: Mean TV for all eight conditions. Primary columns use non-anchor rows of the 14 Scrum and 11 Chrome targets. Complete-table columns use all rows of 25 Scrum targets and 36 external SE targets; the latter averages four publication families, not only Chrome. No cross-stratum accuracy mean is formed.

Method	Prompt	Evidence	Scrum primary	Chrome primary	Scrum complete	External SE complete
Direct	Baseline	None	0.3180	0.2214	0.2620	0.1773
Direct	Baseline	RAG	0.3226	0.2194	0.2660	0.1813
Direct	Structured	None	0.3150	0.2259	0.2548	0.1751
Direct	Structured	RAG	0.3181	0.2225	0.2594	0.1743
RNM	Baseline	None	0.2792	0.2486	0.2353	0.2145
RNM	Baseline	RAG	0.2745	0.2539	0.2346	0.2166
RNM	Structured	None	0.2729	0.2509	0.2302	0.2152
RNM	Structured	RAG	0.2778	0.2534	0.2335	0.2147

Table 4: RNM diagnostics for primary targets. Raw and fitted anchor errors are against the reference. Fit residual is TV between fitted and raw LLM anchors. All use the primary aggregation weights.

Quantity	Scrum	Chrome
Raw LLM anchor TV	0.2790	0.2491
Fitted anchor TV	0.2762	0.2994
Fit residual TV	0.0678	0.1253
Reconstructed non-anchor TV	0.2761	0.2517

5 Discussion

Compact elicitation trades representational freedom for fewer judgments. The same LLM configuration and fitting procedure improve Scrum agreement but worsen Chrome agreement. Elicitation strategy therefore depends on the conditional relationship being represented as well as individual judgment quality.

5.1 When does the RNM constraint help?

RNM encodes ordinal judgments through a few interpretable parameters [8]. The Scrum result is consistent with compatibility between its RNM-derived reference and the fitted representation: extending anchors works better than requesting every row. This supports the evaluated pipeline on that reference, without independently validating probabilities for Scrum teams.

Chrome exposes the other side of the constraint. Fitting moves already elicited anchors farther from their reference probabilities, and exact-reference-anchor diagnostics still leave considerable non-anchor error. This pattern cannot be explained entirely by an inability to generate a numerically plausible anchor. A single aligned aggregation family with shared variance may also be insufficient for conditional relationships learned from project measurements. The source study itself emphasizes interdependencies and instability in the relation between code-review measures and defects [11]. Our results do not establish which individual modeling assumption causes the error, but they make representation compatibility a concrete engineering concern, consistent with RNM applicability research [12].

Ordinal eligibility does not guarantee good approximation. Before adopting RNM, engineers can inspect influence assumptions, fit residuals, and independently validated configurations. Residuals measure consistency with elicited judgments; validation measures agreement with domain evidence. The small Scrum anchor improvement and unfavorable Chrome change also caution against describing RNM as general denoising.

5.2 What the prompt and evidence results establish

Structured prompting benefits direct Scrum elicitation but not the other adjusted comparisons. Nafar et al. likewise distinguish query-granularity effects from prompt modifications [14]. Their strategy asks more questions within rows; ours requests fewer rows. These complementary dimensions cannot be ranked across studies with different metrics and references.

Qualitative RAG did not consistently improve fidelity and worsened direct Scrum agreement under the paired-t analysis. Both arms already had detailed definitions, so the added cards may have offered little information that identifies numerical probabilities. This interpretation differs from claiming that retrieval is ineffective. Clinical modeling work evaluates retrieval and expert usability [4]; reconstruction from statistical summaries supplies quantitative constraints [9]; and Expert-Driven Priors incorporate observations

Table 5: RQ2: complete-table TV differences, averaging the other prompt/evidence factor equally. "Prompt" means structured minus baseline; "RAG" means RAG minus no RAG. External SE comprises four publication families. Negative differences favor the added support. Holm adjustment covers eight contrasts.

Reference stratum	Method	Contrast	Δ	Pointwise 95% CI	Raw t p	Holm t p
Scrum	Direct	Prompt	−0.00692	[−0.00843, −0.00541]	0.000220	0.001761
Scrum	Direct	RAG	+0.00430	[+0.00289, +0.00572]	0.001082	0.007575
Scrum	RNM	Prompt	−0.00313	[−0.00943, +0.00318]	0.240329	1.000000
Scrum	RNM	RAG	+0.00132	[−0.00237, +0.00500]	0.377615	1.000000
External SE	Direct	Prompt	−0.00462	[−0.01205, +0.00282]	0.159742	0.958452
External SE	Direct	RAG	+0.00163	[−0.00412, +0.00738]	0.475067	1.000000
External SE	RNM	Prompt	−0.00060	[−0.00798, +0.00678]	0.832498	1.000000
External SE	RNM	RAG	+0.00085	[−0.00556, +0.00726]	0.731511	1.000000

Table 6: RQ3: observed tokens including repairs. Totals span five replications; the difference and its interval refer to *one replication's* paired method totals. Workloads combine strata for accounting only, not for accuracy inference. Holm adjustment covers four contrasts. All exact sign tests give raw $p = 0.0625$, adjusted $p = 0.25$.

Targets	Counter	Direct total	RNM total	Reduction	Mean block Δ [95% CI]	Raw t p	Holm t p
All 61	Output	341,153	299,798	12.12%	−8,271 [−9,417, −7,125]	0.000037	0.000110
All 61	Input + output	14,697,090	14,607,517	0.61%	−17,915 [−39,331, +3,502]	0.080921	0.080921
Primary 25	Output	213,972	153,463	28.28%	−12,102 [−13,111, −11,093]	0.000005	0.000019
Primary 25	Input + output	6,384,519	6,196,992	2.94%	−37,505 [−58,833, −16,178]	0.008146	0.016292

after elicitation [14]. These approaches answer different information needs.

For SE practice, a plausible future role is to initialize a general model and then adapt context-sensitive parameters using company measurements and focused expert input. Our experiment evaluates initialization against existing references; it does not test that adaptation. A follow-up should hold out organizational observations and assess whether limited local elicitation improves predictions or decisions. General descriptions of good practices alone cannot be assumed to identify a particular organization's frequencies.

5.3 Implications for hybrid AI engineering

RNM requests 40.1% fewer distributions, yet total tokens fall by only 0.61% overall and 2.94% on primary targets. Input overhead, reasoning, repairs, and fitting belong in efficiency claims. This extends the human burden–fidelity perspective [1] to resources observed in an LLM client.

For neurosymbolic systems, the practical contribution is a tested boundary of combining neural judgments with an explicit probabilistic representation. Such a combination makes assumptions and parameters available for inspection, but that property does not itself ensure numerical fidelity. Compared with hybrid inference work such as BIRD [7], our evaluation isolates a parameterization decision and shows why the structured component also needs empirical validation. RNM is a promising option when its assumptions are supported; direct elicitation remains a relevant comparator when those assumptions restrict important interactions.

6 Threats to Validity

The study's main limitations concern the meaning of the reference, the constraints imposed by reconstruction, and the extent of repeated-run inference.

Construct validity. TV measures agreement with a contextual CPT, not calibration against observed outcomes, expert replacement, explanation quality, or decision utility. Equal-row scoring includes configurations that may be rare in operation. The Scrum reference is numerically reconstructed rather than independently certified by an AgenaRisk export, and its RNM origin creates a structural advantage for the tested representation. Separate strata and the raw-versus-fitted diagnostics expose that distinction. The SESSI table represents an original elicitation stage. Source-to-export semantic adaptations and uncertain influence signs may affect agreement even when numerical indexing is correct.

Internal validity. Fresh sessions, shared definitions, configuration hashes, and blinded fitting limit carryover and leakage. Public benchmark memorization remains possible, and the model alias does not establish the backend snapshot. Earlier development involved Scrum, reducing its independence as an evaluation object. The method contrast combines anchor selection, LLM family selection, direction alignment, and fitting; it does not isolate one component. Bounded search may miss better fits. Schema validation does not establish semantic correctness of every response or evidence citation; comprehensive human fidelity review was not performed. Packets and structured instructions are treatment bundles.

Conclusion validity. Five blocks give little evidence about the distribution or stationarity of differences. The paired-t and exact-sign results must be considered together; neither treats shared nodes or rows as independent replications. Scope selection and testing were post hoc, and separate Holm families do not provide study-wide confirmatory error control. No prespecified acceptable-error margin supports claims of equivalence or practical sufficiency. Repeated execution estimates here are conditional on these fixed references and settings.

External validity. The primary comparison contains one external publication family (Chrome) and one Scrum model. The 61-target sample spans more settings, but many targets do not test multi-parent compression, and tables have at most 27 rows. Only one requested model and reasoning effort were evaluated. Organizational distributions, larger CPTs, other model families, and evidence containing local numerical measurements may yield different trade-offs. The excluded sensing and cyber-physical data do not support domain comparisons in this paper.

7 Conclusion

We compared direct and RNM-assisted LLM elicitation across 61 ordinal SE targets, eight conditions, and five replications. On the 25 primary targets, RNM improved agreement with the reconstructed Scrum reference and worsened agreement with Chrome. Both directions persisted across replications, with paired-t support but no exact-sign rejection at 0.05. Structured prompting and qualitative evidence did not consistently improve agreement. RNM reduced requested judgments and output tokens, while total-token savings were limited.

Compact elicitation should therefore be evaluated against the relationships it represents. Future work should test whether validated influence assumptions and limited organizational evidence make such an initialization useful for local decisions, connecting inspectability to practical reliability.

Replication Materials

The replication package separates collection-only prompts and execution controls from evaluator-only references, fitted predictions, and analysis scripts. It preserves the five replication blocks, scope decisions, usage counters, and statistical contrasts. The repository is private during author review; a public or anonymous release is not claimed here.

Use of Generative AI

LLM-generated probability judgments are the experimental data described in Section 3. Generative AI also assisted with manuscript drafting and with preparation and checking of scripts and summaries. These roles are distinct from the experimental runs. Numerical claims are traceable to saved responses and deterministic analyses; AI-generated prose is not used as scientific evidence.

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